

A Coloured World

Also Remember...

- Cartridge life is usually expressed keeping in mind just 5 per cent of the page being covered by ink. The practical life of a cartridge will vary according to type of printing done.
- Cartridge cost is an important consideration. You also need to consider the cost of exchanging a print head, which is almost half the cost of the printer. The average lifecycle of a print head is around 18 months for most users.
- To judge print quality, take a look at a few sample printouts on plain paper before making a decision.
- Dpi ratings can be somewhat misleading.
- Duplexing is the ability to print on both sides of a page. It is a useful paper saving feature but usually costs extra.

Inkjet printers have become really popular due to the fact that they provide users with the ability to print in colour at a fraction of the cost of even basic monochrome laser printers. This popularity has been driven in large part by the fact that people with computers at home want the ability to print documents, greeting cards and photos from their personal albums.

Hewlett-Packard, Epson and Canon are some of the heavyweights in this segment. HP and Canon use a thermal inkjet printing technology, while Epson uses its own piezoelectric printing process.

Prices for entry-level inkjet printers begin from about Rs 5,000 and go up to about Rs 50,000. Most users however will probably find a suitable printer for less than Rs 15,000.

TECHNOLOGY INSIGHT

Inkjets work by impinging charged ink particles onto paper by using magnetised plates to direct the ink into the required patterns. They are well suited to producing both quality text and images. Several models are capable of printing photo realistic images, though for best results you need to use special paper.



cost of printing each colour page is higher than comparable colour laser printers, the price of the printer itself is much lower.

Connections: Check to see that your computer has the right kind of port for the printer you have selected. While newer models have USB ports, the parallel port models are also quite common. For networks, a printer should be able connect directly to the network.

SMART TIPS

Resolution: This is measured in dots per inch, which is a rough measure of the image quality you can expect. There are image-processing techniques, however, that can improve the output quality considerably. Edge enhancement and Print Image Matching are two such technologies.

Speed: Print speed will vary according to the type of material that you are printing and the print mode that you have selected. Print speeds are usually inversely proportional to print quality.

Colour: Although low-end inkjets don't offer great quality, the high-end ones offer photo quality output when printed at high resolution on glossy paper. Although the

Paper and ink capacity: The cost of consumables for inkjet printers can be quite high and cartridges will need regular replacement. Low-end printers use a single colour cartridge that requires replacement whenever any one of the three colours runs out. High-end printers use separate cartridges for each ink type.

Paper handling: Check that the printer can accommodate the paper sizes and volumes you plan to use.

Memory: Printers come with a buffer (RAM), which is a temporary store for information. A larger buffer allows storage of high-resolution documents or a larger number of regular documents.

	Home use	Intermediate (under Rs 15,000)	Photorealistic printing (under Rs 30,000)
You need	Average output quality and you are OK with slow speeds. A low purchase price is important	Faster printing and are willing to pay a little extra for larger paper size options and higher print quality	Something that can give you photorealistic printouts and are not willing to compromise on quality
Look for	An A4 printer with the ability to print colour. Resolution of 1440x720 dpi would be sufficient	Faster print speeds and options such as photo cartridges or larger paper sizes up to A3. These printers offer better print quality and longer life per ink cartridge	Printers with resolution in the order of 1200x1200 dpi, 2400x1200 dpi, or 2880x1440 dpi. You might want the option of six-colour printing
Our pick	Canon BJC 3000, Epson Stylus Color 880	Lexmark Z52	HP DeskJet 990Cxi
Price range	Up to Rs 8,000	Up to Rs 15,000	Up to Rs. 30,000



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